

*Develop activities that will promote transfer of learning for both the **technical support staff and faculty**. Students should be able to justify their activities based on possible conclusions drawn from a contextual analysis.*

Example (for faculty learners): If Ross had conducted a context analysis, he would have determined that the Fine Arts faculty needed a convenient way to post images on the Web for students to review out of class. A useful activity to promote transfer of learning would be to have faculty scan images and post them to the Web using WebPath, and then to develop effective review questions to post with the images. Following training, faculty should be directed to work with their departmental technical support staff to scan other images, post them, and develop homework assignments around the images.

Example (for technical support staff): If Ross had conducted a context analysis, he would have determined that the Fine Arts technical support staff had limited ability to distinguish effective instructional uses of technology from less effective uses. A useful activity to promote transfer of learning would be to have support staff review best practices of web-based instruction and develop a checklist of critical success factors that they could use with the faculty in their department.

It is clear from the reading that not all faculty members thrill about WebPath and its use. Furthermore, not all 750 faculty members at Lane State West (LSW) need to be trained to use WebPath. For example, WebPath does not provide a facility for math and physics faculty members to easily produce specialized characters required for their disciplines. Many of these faculty members have stated that WebPath does nothing for them. Perhaps, these faculty members may find a use of it when WebPath is more mature and stable.

Of the seven faculty members involved in the pilot training program, nearly half of the faculty members use only the basic functionality of WebPath such as display syllabi, bibliographies of course readings, lectures posted using slideshow lecture notes, and study guides (pg. 86). One faculty member has also abandoned the WebPath course altogether, because he/she can get the necessary help from the technical support staff.

This case has also indicated that not only faculty but also students have problems adopting WebPath, and that the technical support staff have problems learning it or lack technical skills. According to the reading, the technical support staff members are not yet familiar with WebPath and have limited knowledge of how WebPath might be used to support effective instructional strategies. It looks like many features of WebPath are either not ready for prime time, not yet implemented, or due to vendor-specific issues (or software bugs). For example, some faculty members have stated that they like online chat features, but it's not yet available.

Even though there are many issues with adopting new tools, usability, etc., many faculty members also have positive reviews of their experiences using WebPath (pg. 87). Some faculty members like the feature for scanning artwork and posting image files for students to review.

Training, technical, usability, supportability, and vendor-specific issues are common problems for early adopters of any software system. It may take a few years to get people excited and learn the new systems. In the case study, the training pilot is new and too early to tell the effective use of WebPath. Two academic terms (fall and spring) are just enough time to get the faculty members talking. I feel that there is a lot of resistance from faculty members to using technology in the classroom compared to traditional classrooms.

In this situation, I think the best way to get people involved in this kind of training is to give them all some incentive for it. The incentive can be anything from time off from work for the training to recognition for their training efforts, and, at the same time, encourage all participants to promote the transfer of knowledge to others. In this case, both the technical support staff and faculty members are encouraged to promote knowledge transfer and foster collaboration with each other.

I like the idea of an observation checklist in this case, so that WebPath administrators can observe all learning participants and their needs. To get people excited, motivated, and involved, I think the director of OTC/Ross needs to provide them with all the necessary tools, equipment, and other resources to learn. This means that OTC/Ross gives all participants easy access to the system (user accounts, documents, and so on) and on-demand technical assistance. The better these participants are at using WebPath, the more eager and motivated they are to help others and promote their use. If some faculty members know how to use video conferencing, they would be more motivated to create video conferencing training sessions, and if they like the online chat feature, they will promote its use. The point is that if people understand what they are learning, then they are much more motivated and more involved. I think that many training manuals, white papers, red papers, and other training materials are derived from this kind of activity. At the same time, I think that management needs to encourage and promote these kinds of training activities.

I like these links, and they are related to what I am talking about: collaboration training.

Strategies To Promote Congruency of Training and Practice for Preschool Staff Development from

http://www.eric.ed.gov/ERICWebPortal/custom/portlets/recordDetails/detailmini.jsp?_nfpb=true&_ERICExtSearch_SearchValue_0=ED296789&ERICExtSearch_SearchType_0=eric_accno&accno=ED296789

Collaboration Between General and Special Education: Making it Work from

<http://www.ncset.org/publications/viewdesc.asp?id=1097>

Report of Collaborative Training Account (CTA) Managers Workshop from

<http://www.epsr.ac.uk/CMSWeb/Downloads/Other/CTAManagersWorkshopReport.pdf>